

Forest Bathing: A Shinrin-Yoku Practice Guide

A two-page protocol guide to shinrin-yoku — the sensory-sequence practice, dosing and frequency drawn from the cortisol and natural-killer-cell research, and a printable checklist for structuring your own sessions.

1. Before You Start

- ☐ **Choose real tree cover, not just any outdoor space**
The research is specific to forest and substantial-tree-density environments — it is not a general "go outside" finding.
- ☐ **Skip the fitness tracker and pace goals**
Studied protocols are slow and unhurried, not exercise. Tracking distance or heart-rate zones works against the mechanism.
- ☐ **Wear comfortable, broken-in footwear**
Discomfort undermines the slow, sensory-focused pacing the protocols depend on more than people expect.
- ☐ **Set aside 20 minutes to 2 hours**
Most studied protocols fall in this range. Twenty minutes is roughly the point at which the parasympathetic ("rest and digest") system begins to dominate.

2. The Sensory Sequence

- ☐ **Walk under 1 kilometer, with no destination**
Clinical protocols typically cover well under a mile over one to two hours — distance is not the point.
- ☐ **Slow down until it feels too slow**
Pace goals defeat the mechanism. Feeling like you are moving too slowly is a normal, expected part of the first few sessions.
- ☐ **Notice texture before anything else**
Touch bark, leaves, or stone. Tactile engagement anchors attention in the present more reliably than sight alone.
- ☐ **Cycle deliberately through sound, temperature, and smell**
Rotate attention across senses rather than defaulting to looking at scenery.

3. Frequency & Consistency

☐ **Treat it as repeatable, not a one-time fix**

Measured cortisol reductions are acute rather than lasting from a single session — similar to exercise or meditation.

☐ **Start with one or two sessions per week**

Enough to build consistency without requiring a major time investment.

☐ **Track how you feel afterward, not during**

Subjective relief has been reported even in trials where objective anxiety scores did not shift — both signals are worth noting.

☐ **Substitute urban green space when forest isn't accessible**

Studies on urban dwellers still found benefits from meaningful tree density and reduced ambient noise, at a smaller magnitude.

4. What the Research Actually Shows

☐ **Pooled cortisol reduction: 12–18%**

A 2019 meta-analysis in the International Journal of Biometeorology found this effect following short-term forest exposure across pooled studies.

☐ **Phytoncide exposure is linked to natural-killer-cell activity**

Airborne compounds released by trees are associated with increased NK-cell activity in blood samples, though this evidence is less robust than the cortisol findings.

☐ **Results are not universally consistent**

At least one randomized trial found no significant difference in objective anxiety scores versus control, even though participants reported feeling subjectively better.

This guide is educational and summarizes findings from peer-reviewed nature-therapy research. It is not a substitute for treatment of clinical anxiety or chronic stress — a licensed clinician can help determine whether additional support is appropriate.